

Virtual shopping

A recent survey by playspan revealed that women spend \$55 for purchasing virtual currency on social games whereas men spend \$30

Geeky wedding

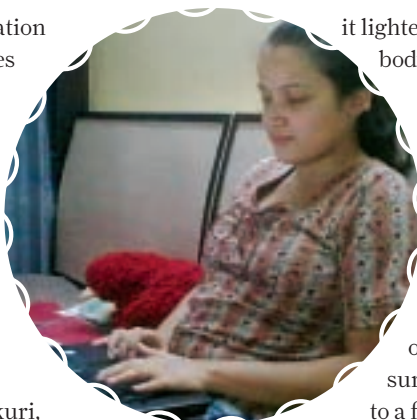
A geeky bride to be gave her equally geeky fiancé a USB flash drive wedding ring

Cover feature

by the National Association of Software and Services Companies (Nasscom) conducted in 2007, predicted that by 2010, women will make up half of the workforce in the IT and ITES sectors, up from a fourth of the total employee base at the time of the report. Sharvari Atmakuri, 22 year old Digit reader and Software Engineer from Bangalore reaffirmed this "Women are very high on technology and tech jobs

lately. In fact there are more women in my team at Wipro. My TL is a woman too." The proverbial glass ceiling is about to be shattered if it hasn't already. Another example is of Noopur Julka, who is a Java Developer at Accenture, who says she likes coding for fun. "Setting up new widgets, tweaking codes on my blog definitely feels great," she says.

One of the most unique women we came across was T Bhargavi a housewife from a remote village of Chittoor district of Andhra Pradesh who retrofitted a computer cabinet to design her very own wirefree and portable all-in-one computer. The idea for the 'Cabtop' as she calls it, was a result of her getting fed up with all the cable clutter that her husband's computer created. "I wanted to pack it all up into one neat little box", she said. So she drew up plans to restructure the layout for the innards of a computer and verified feasibility with her brother, who happened to be a network engineer. She got the initial funding from Department of Science and Industrial Research under the *Technopreneur Promotion Programme* and now she's looking for further infusion to make



"I would love to spend the whole day online if I could"

Kanika Sud, Msc IT student from Simla

it lighter with an all plastic body and take it retail.

One of the things we wondered about during the course of research for this story was: are these women geeky because their male sibling's geekiness rubbed off on them? From our surveys we could not come to a firm conclusion. We have someone like Sharvari who learnt to play games and trouble shoot her PC from her brother, while 24-year old

media professional, Joyeeta Chakravorty is a hardcore console gamer but we found no male siblings to whom we could attribute this to. "I've enjoyed playing the Max Payne Series, Conflict Global Storm, FIFA 2010, and God of War on my PS2", she told us. "I've played video games ranging from the rowdy Doom days to the strategic Sims era. No male influence contributed to this sheer

love for entertainment", the ever opinionated Gursimran seconded. Well it could simply be that women are getting comfortable with their geek-iality. But some such as Kanika, were reluctant to accept the moniker of a geek. Could this reluctance be because there is a bias in our society against women who are tech savvy? "Absolutely not," said Gursimran. "I think the society is in awe of women who know their tech". "Come to think of it, there is a certain amount of awe and respect for a tech savvy girl in the house," Kanika also admitted.



"Having women specific designs or gadgets is good, as long as they pass the required quality tests for any device."

Joyeeta Chakravorty, media professional from New Delhi

Pink or no pink?

One of the age old questions about what women want when it comes to gadgets is this - do women care about specifications or is it all like "ooh that's pretty, I want." Product makers have tried to go both ways on this one. On one hand you have Nokia coming out with product lines such as the Supernova series and the likes of Dell and Sony with nail polish lacquer notebook tops. These approaches, some might consider rather patronising, if the products themselves were vacuous or atrociously priced. On the other hand you have Blackberrys that are probably used by just

as many women as men, yet

we haven't come across a

Pink Blackberry as yet.

We asked the fairer sex what they felt.

"I can understand why there is a certain approach manufacturers use to reach out to either genders. It is not about a 'bias' or a 'stereotype'," said Gursimran. "I do realise

women like gadgets that are more portable, easier to use and look sleeker than their cruder counterparts. But if

looks was all it had, give me the bulky brick of a gadget anyway," she adds. This seemed to be seconded by almost all the women we spoke to. Sravani said, "We like aesthetics and even pink gadgets, yes. In fact I own a pink Dell Studio laptop. If there was a choice between really good specs and aesthetics I'd go for the specs. Kanika, who herself owns a Supernova series phone said that specifications are important in certain product categories. "When I went for my point & shoot digicam specs trumped the looks," she justified.

Diamonds or Gadgets?

This is the final clincher to settle any doubts you might have about women being geeky. "I'd sell my diamonds for gadgets, no questions asked" said Gursimran to our quirky question. End of story. 



"I like code"

Noopur Julka, Java Developer at Accenture